

Monkeys, Chimps & Gorillas: Wētā FX's (r)Evolutionary Work with Primates

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1 Description

Wētā FX is known for many things in the VFX world, but one of their hallmarks is pretty bananas... From Peter Jackson's King Kong, to Caesar in Rise, Dawn, and War of the Planet of the Apes, through to The Umbrella Academy's loveable and intelligent chimpanzee, Pogo, the team has done it all.

But what has this repeat monkey business meant for workflows and innovations that have all led up to the latest instalment of the Apes franchise, Kingdom of the Planet of the Apes? In this talk, Visual Effects Supervisor's Erik Winquist, Kevin Smith, Paul Story, and Phillip Leonhardt and Animation Supervisor, Aidan Martin, will chart the evolution of this particular kind of character work, and the unique workflows that always make audiences go ape. In this session, the panel will take a look at Wētā FX's first foray into primates, starting with 2005's King Kong, to discuss how the fully CG character marked a true technical achievement for the Animation, Motion Capture, and Facial Animation departments at the time. All things that laid the foundational approach for all primate characters that would follow.

Jumping forward to 2011's Rise of the Planet of the Apes, the panel will share insight into what it was like to reimagine the classic franchise's main characters digitally for the first time, and explore the further enhancements to performance capture and facial performance systems that enabled audiences to emotionally connect to the characters. The panel will share the challenges the Wētā team had to overcome and how it further shaped how VFX artists approach primates - and creatures in general - in the VFX world.



Using the knowledge gained from Wētā's multitude of monkeys over the years, the team will reflect on bringing their most human-like primate, Pogo, to life. As one of Wētā's more sophisticated characters, Pogo has been dressed in various costumes, fur grooms, and ages - but the spirit of Pogo has remained true while the team embraced the characters' many variations.

To wrap up this evolutionary journey, this session will introduce the host of new simian characters that have been welcomed into the Wētā family in 2024 in both Godzilla x Kong: The New Empire, and Kingdom of the Planet of the Apes - sharing the modern techniques to bringing the variety of primates to life.

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